

FREE BONUS

Water Bath Canning Checklist Pack

Follow these step by step and avoid the most common beginner mistakes

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WHAT'S INSIDE THIS PACK

✓ **CHECKLIST 1 — Equipment List**
Everything you need and what to prepare before every canning session.

✓ **CHECKLIST 2 — Step-by-Step Process Checklist**
From preparing your jars and ingredients to the 12–24-hour seal check.

Both checklists are printable. Keep them in the kitchen while you work.

CHECKLIST 1

Equipment List

Everything you need before your first session — most of it you may already own.

A. EQUIPMENT INVENTORY — DO YOU HAVE EVERYTHING?

- ☐ Boiling-water canner (or any deep pot with a lid and a rack — see note below)
- ☐ Mason jars — half-pint (jams, jellies, preserves) and pint (fruits, tomatoes, pickles, salsas)
- ☐ Flat lids — NEW every session (single use only)
- ☐ Screw bands/rings (reusable if not rusted or bent)
- ☐ Jar lifter — non-negotiable
- ☐ Canning funnel
- ☐ Bubble remover (or a thin plastic spatula)
- ☐ Headspace tool (or a ruler)
- ☐ Kitchen timer (or phone)
- ☐ Permanent marker + labels
- ☐ Clean damp cloths or paper towels for rim wiping

Optional but useful

- ☐ Lid wand / magnetic lid lifter
- ☐ Candy or jelly thermometer — only needed for recipes that reach a gel point (jellies, marmalade)

> ⚠️ **No dedicated boiling-water canner? No problem.**
>
> Any pot deep enough to cover your jars by at least 1 inch of boiling water — without splashing over — will work. A standard stockpot with a rack is a perfectly good substitute. What you should never use: commercial food jars (from store-bought salsa, pickles, or pasta sauce). They're not made for the thermal stress of canning and may break or fail to seal. Use only jars manufactured for home canning — Ball, Kerr, or equivalent.

B. BEFORE YOUR FIRST SESSION — DO THIS ONCE

- ☐ Find your altitude (nationalmap.gov or your local Cooperative Extension office) and write it down — every recipe's processing time depends on it
- ☐ Read the full recipe before you start — some require advance prep (overnight standing, 24-hour refrigeration, or several hours of salting)

> 💡 **Pro tip**
>
> Finding your altitude only takes a minute and you only need to do it once. Checking for advance prep, though, is worth doing every time you pick a new recipe — the day before, not the morning of.

CHECKLIST 2

Step-by-Step Canning Process

Follow in order. Do not skip steps. Keep this open on the counter while you work.

BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ Check your recipe for advance prep — start the day before if it needs overnight standing, 24-hour refrigeration, or salting
- ☐ Confirm your altitude and find the matching column in Appendix A
- ☐ Check jar inventory — wash, inspect rims, set aside enough for the batch
- ☐ Prepare and measure all ingredients, seasonings, and canning liquid (syrup, brine, or sauce)
- ☐ Check you have new lids and enough sugar, salt, vinegar, or pectin as the recipe requires

STEP 1 — Set Up Your Workspace and Fill the Canner

- ☐ Clear and clean the counter space next to your stove
- ☐ Place the rack inside the canner; fill with water to cover jars by at least 1 inch (about 6–8 inches for pint jars)
- ☐ Bring water to a simmer (180°F) over medium heat — hot, not boiling
- ☐ Wash all tools with hot soapy water

> 💡 **Pro tip**
>
> Starting the canner early is the single most useful habit in water bath canning. A pot of water takes 20–30 minutes to come to temperature — start it when you begin prepping your produce and it'll be ready exactly when you need it.

STEP 2 — Prepare and Heat Your Jars

- ☐ Wash jars in hot soapy water; inspect rims — discard any with chips or cracks
- ☐ Keep jars hot until ready to fill (simmering canner, a separate pot of hot water, or a dishwasher heated-dry cycle)
- ☐ Wash lids and bands in warm soapy water — do not pre-boil lids
- ☐ If your recipe needs sterilized jars (jams, jellies, or processing times under 10 minutes): boil empty jars covered by 1 inch of water for 10 minutes, plus 1 minute per 1,000 ft of altitude

STEP 3 — Prepare Your Produce and Recipe

- ☐ Follow your recipe's prep instructions exactly
- ☐ Measure all ingredients before you start
- ☐ Have your canning liquid made and hot before filling the first jar
- ☐ Prepare seasoning and any add-ins

STEP 4 — Fill the Jars

- ☐ Work one jar at a time
- ☐ Remove a hot jar, shake off excess water, and set it on a towel

- ☐ Place the canning funnel in the jar opening
- ☐ Add any required acid first — bottled lemon juice or citric acid, if the recipe calls for it
- ☐ Fill with prepared food, then ladle hot liquid to cover, leaving the headspace the recipe specifies
- ☐ Run the bubble remover around the inside of the jar; recheck headspace
- ☐ Wipe the rim with a damp cloth — all the way around
- ☐ Center a clean lid, sealing side down
- ☐ Thread the band to fingertip-tight — no forcing

> ✓ **LAST CHECK BEFORE LOADING THE CANNER**
>
> ☐ Correct headspace on every jar
> ☐ No air bubbles visible
> ☐ Jar rim clean and dry
> ☐ Lid centered and band fingertip-tight
> ☐ All jars upright and ready

STEP 5 — Load the Canner and Bring to a Full Boil

- ☐ Lower jars one at a time onto the rack using the jar lifter — keep upright at all times
- ☐ Leave a little space between jars so water can circulate
- ☐ Add boiling water if needed so jars stay covered by at least 1 inch
- ☐ Place the lid on the canner and bring to a full rolling boil over high heat

> 💡 **Pro tip**
>
> If you need to top up the water level, use boiling water from a separate kettle. Cold water drops the canner's temperature and adds time before processing can even begin.

STEP 6 — Process

- ☐ Start your timer once the water reaches a full rolling boil
- ☐ Use the processing time and altitude column from Appendix A
- ☐ Maintain a steady boil throughout; keep the lid on
- ☐ Avoid lifting the lid unnecessarily — every time it comes off, you lose heat and add time

> ⚠️ **If the water stops boiling at any point during processing**
>
> Return it to a full boil and restart the timer from zero. Partial processing is not safe processing.

STEP 7 — Remove Jars and Check Seals

- ☐ Turn off the heat; remove the lid, tilting it away from you
- ☐ Let the canner sit undisturbed 5 minutes before lifting jars

- ☐ Lift jars out one at a time with the jar lifter, keeping them upright
- ☐ Place on a towel or rack with at least 1 inch between jars
- ☐ Do not tilt jars, press lids, or retighten bands
- ☐ Let cool undisturbed 12–24 hours

THE 12–24-HOUR SEAL CHECK

- ☐ Remove screw bands
- ☐ Press test: lid does not flex when pressed at the center (concave = sealed)

> ✅ **If sealed:**
> ☐ Wash the outside of the jar
> ☐ Label and store

> ❌ **If not sealed:**
> ☐ Refrigerate and use within a few days
> ☐ OR reprocess within 24 hours with a new lid and the full original processing time

LABEL EVERY JAR BEFORE STORING

- ☐ Contents — be specific: “Peach Jam” not “Jam”
- ☐ Date canned — month and year
- ☐ Store upright in a cool, dark, dry place, ideally 50–70°F (10–21°C)